as the parameter. For example, to find students who have fees less than a particular amount, type `< [Fees lesser than:]` in the Fees field of your table. When you click on the saved query, a message box pops up prompting you to enter a value for the chosen parameter. So if you need to find students who pay fees less than 500, enter 500 as the parameter.

Imagine building the same query every month—just use Reports for...well...regular reports!

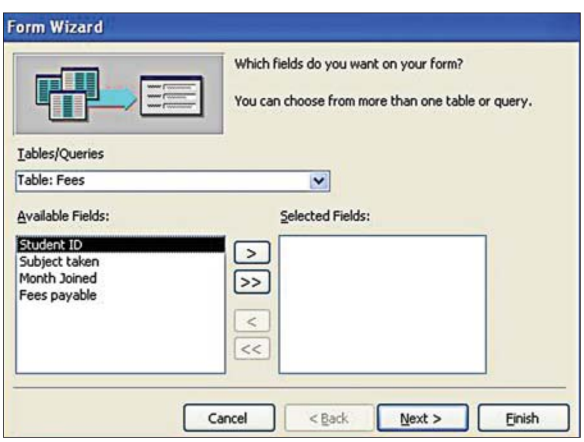
Forms

These represent another data element in Access. Forms are mainly used to enter data into tables, and to view data. They can be used to edit data as well. They are also used to make a splash-screen or a "switchboard"—an entry screen where tabs and buttons guide you to the major parts of the database. Well-designed forms serve to demystify a database for first-time users who might be apprehensive of using one. Besides, they are easy on the eyes.

Forms are of five types—columnar, tabular, datasheet, pivot table, and pivot chart. Pivot tables and pivot charts are like bar diagrams—they are used to efficiently summarise and visually display large amounts of data according to set parameters. To create a form, you can use either Design view or the Wizard. For our sample database, we chose the Wizard.

Select your data fields from the field list. You can use tables or queries as the data source, but make sure the fields come from tables and queries where the fields have certain relations. Table relations may be one-to-one, many-to-one, or many-to-many: these refer to the different permutations in which fields in one table relate with fields in other tables. For instance, one single student might take up more than one subject. This would create a one-to-many relationship.

There is also the concept of subforms in Access. A subform is a smaller form that can be embedded in a larger form. Subforms are particularly suitable for complex databases. If you



The Form Wizard takes some of the headache out of form-making

want to create subforms or create other types of forms using the Wizard, select New in the Database window. Choose your form type and the table or query from where your form gets the data. In our database, we used forms to enter data for the student info table. Click on Create form by using Wizard and choose Student info table as the source. Choose all the fields from the source table, select layout and style, and click Finish. You will be able to check out the data in the Student info table, edit it, and add new data. Any changes or additions you make will be reflected in the Student info table.

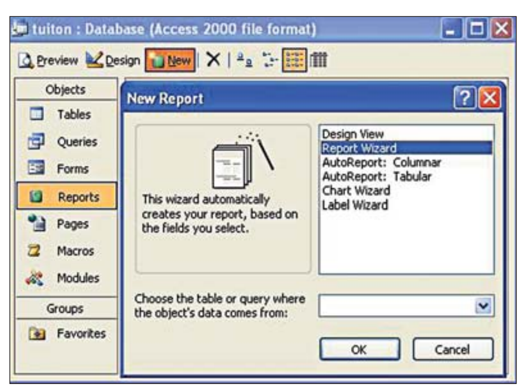
The Student Info Form

Reports

As the name indicates, reports are usually used to represent data in easily viewable or printable formats. Tables and queries are used as data sources for reports. You can design reports to represent the way you want to display the data: sort data in alphabetical or in increasing / decreasing order, and display sum, average, maximum, and minimum of data. If the report runs into multiple pages, you can add page numbers. Access gives you the option to display data in visual form.

For beginners, the best way of creating reports is using the Wizard. This way you can create autoreports—using a single table or query as the data source—in columnar and tabular forms, or you can pick and choose your fields using the Report Wizard. There are Wizards for representing data in visual format (the Chart Wizard) and another to print out labels.

In the Report tab, click New and choose the type of report you want. For our student database, we used the Autoreport Wizard. We chose the data source as the query for the number of students joining in January. After clicking Finish, we got a nice, printed report.



A sample view of the Report Wizard